The `action.destructive_requires_name` property is set to `true` by default, so you may receive a "Wildcard expressions or all indices are not allowed" error when trying to delete indexes using a wildcard or `_all`.

> **WARNING** Deleting indexes accidentally can result in permanent data loss. When you are working with `DELETE` APIs, caution is advised, because accidental invocations can destabilize the system.

DELETING ONLY ALIASES

In addition to deleting the whole index, which internally deletes mappings, settings, aliases, and data, there's also a mechanism to delete only aliases. We use the `_alias` API for this purpose.

Listing 6.26 Deleting an alias explicitly

```
DELETE cars/_alias/cars_alias
```

Deletes cars_alias

Deleting an index is a destructive task because data is purged permanently. Needless to say, before issuing this operation, be certain you really want to delete the index and all its configurations and data. Next, let's look at some less destructive operations: closing and opening indexes.

6.5 Closing and opening indexes

Depending on the use case, we can close or open an index—the index is put on hold for further indexing or searching when it is closed. Let's look at the options for closing an index.

6.5.1 Closing indexes

Closing an index means exactly that: it is closed for business, and any operations on it will cease. There will be no indexing of documents or search and analytic queries.

> **NOTE** Because closed indexes are not available for business operations, you must take care before closing an index. Doing so could break the system if indexes are closed but referenced in your code. This is one good reason to depend on aliases rather than real indexes!

The close index API (`_close`) shuts down the index. The syntax is `POST <index_name>/_close`. For example, the following listing closes the `cars` index (until further notice), and thus any operations on it result in errors.

Listing 6.27 Closing the `cars` index indefinitely

```
POST cars/_close
```

This code closes the index for business. No more read/write operations are allowed on it.